

JEANNE SORIN

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Updated April 2026

Academic Positions

Assistant Professor Goldman School of Public Policy, University of California Berkeley	2026–
Postdoctoral Scholar Institute for Climate and Sustainable Growth, University of Chicago	2025–2026

Education

Ph.D. Economics, University of Chicago	2019–2025
M.A. Economics, University of Chicago	2019–2021
M.Sc. Economics, Sciences Po	2016–2019
B.A. Social Sciences, Sciences Po	2013–2015

Research and Teaching Fields

Primary:	Development Economics, Urban and Spatial Economics
Secondary:	Environmental Economics

Publications and Accepted Papers

Learning is in the Air: Clean Air as an Experience Good (with B. Resosudarmo and Y. Sun). **Accepted** at *Journal of Development Economics* based on Pre-Results Review.
AEA RCT Registry No. 0013110

Abstract: Despite the enormous costs of air pollution, willingness-to-pay (WTP) for clean air in polluted developing contexts remains low. We posit one understudied reason is that clean air is an experience good, whose value is revealed after consumption. We test this using a cluster-randomized trial, and seek to document an “experience wedge”, i.e. a difference between anticipated and realized utility of consuming a good. We deploy a novel experience-based intervention, installing air monitors and purifiers, potentially a more salient treatment than traditional information in pamphlets or videos. To explore the mechanisms behind the hypothesized wedge, we implement a purifier-only treatment to distinguish between (1) knowledge about objective pollution exposure and (2) the sensory experience of breathing in clean air. This will be the first experimental evidence demonstrating how experience can shift demand for clean air, with implications for public health policy, environmental awareness campaigns, and using WTP estimates in economic evaluations.

Working Papers

Public Roads on Private Lands: Land Costs and Optimal Road Improvements in Urban Uganda.

Abstract: Despite the need for transportation infrastructure investments in developing cities, empirical evidence on their net returns is lacking due to data constraints and the common oversight of land acquisition costs. In this paper, I collect novel data to estimate the net returns of 140 km of road improvements in Kampala, Uganda, since 2017, accounting for both benefits and land acquisition costs. Using new surveys with real estate brokers and landowners, I exploit variation in the timing of improvements to estimate local benefits. I develop a quantitative spatial model to capture the city-level impacts

of the policy, accounting for general equilibrium effects and heterogeneous land acquisition costs. Leveraging the coexistence of three property rights regimes in the city, I show that weak property rights are associated with lower land acquisition costs. I find that the net welfare gains from the realized road improvements were equivalent to a 119 USD transfer per resident, but would have been negative if land had been acquired at market value, as legally mandated under eminent domain, due to the high cost of raising domestic funds. Finally, I solve for the optimal road improvements under different institutional settings and demonstrate the importance of accounting for land costs when designing, funding, and evaluating transportation infrastructure projects, particularly in low- and middle-income countries where land acquisition relies on fragile land and financial institutions.

Jobs in the Smog: Firm Location and Workers' Exposure to Pollution in African Cities

(with V. Bassi, M. Kahn, N. Lozano Gracia and T. Porzio).

AEA RCT Registry No. 0014162

Abstract: We show that the organization of production prevalent in Ugandan cities increases workers' exposure to urban pollution. Using new granular spatial data on air pollution and manufacturing firms, we document that small firms cluster along the busiest and most polluted roads because road traffic bundles air pollution with customer access. Even within neighborhoods, cleaner areas exist, yet jobs are in the smog. A spatial equilibrium model rationalizes these patterns, with firms capturing sizable profit gains from polluted locations while workers receive limited compensation for the exposure. Our results imply that the welfare costs of urban air pollution in developing-country cities may be substantially larger than city-level averages suggest.

Beyond Stoves and Outdoor Monitors: Indoor PM_{2.5} Exposure and Inequality in a Fast Growing Megacity

(with D. Rahut, B. P. Resosudarmo, D. Suryadarma and Y. Sun).

Revise and Resubmit at *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences (PNAS)*

Abstract: Exposure to fine particulate matter (PM_{2.5}) is the leading environmental risk factor for mortality worldwide. Epidemiological and global health research typically proxies exposure using cooking fuel type and ambient outdoor PM_{2.5} concentrations. Yet urbanization is changing the exposure profile of low- and middle-income country (LMIC) populations who use cleaner fuels and spend most of their time indoors, but live in areas with high outdoor pollution - raising questions about whether either proxy captures actual exposure. We present 152,000 hours of indoor PM_{2.5} monitoring from 283 homes in Jakarta, the world's largest and one of the most polluted cities, where 98% of households have adopted clean cooking fuels. Despite near-universal clean cooking, indoor PM_{2.5} is persistently high; it exceeded the WHO 24-hour guideline value (15 $\mu\text{g}/\text{m}^3$) on 78% of monitored days, with extreme levels invisible to outdoor monitors. We estimate an infiltration factor 2-3 times larger than in high-income countries and find that the majority of indoor PM_{2.5} originates outdoors. We uncover stark exposure inequality: low-income households experience 112% higher indoor PM_{2.5} than high-income households despite similar outdoor exposure. This inequality is mostly driven by differences in indoor emission sources, particularly smoking. Low-cost indoor monitoring reveals what neither cooking fuel type nor outdoor concentrations can capture: actual indoor exposure and its stark distributional consequences in rapidly urbanizing megacities.

Work in Progress

Traffic Solutions in Delhi. (with Michael Greenstone and Anant Sudarshan)

French Railroad Shrinkage.

Awards, Scholarships

Young Economist Prize - European Economic Association

2025

Theodore Schultz Economics Fellowship Award	2024 - 2025
Certificate in Urban Science & Sustainable Development (University of Chicago)	2023
Graduate Fellowship (University of Chicago)	2019 - 2024
EPIC DRW Graduate Fellowship (University of Chicago)	2019 - 2024
Best Master's Thesis (Sciences Po)	2019
<i>Cum laude</i> (top 10%) bachelor degree (Sciences Po)	2016

Grants

Research Grant (w. Y. Sun et al.) (Asian Development Bank) (\$99,548)	2024
Research Grant (w. Y. Sun) (WEISS) (\$49,391)	2023
PhD Research Grant (STEG-CEPR) (\$19,458)	2023
Development Economics Research Fund (University of Chicago) (\$14,105)	2023
Lloyd and Susanne Rudolph Fieldwork Award (CISSR) (\$4,800)	2023
Pilot Grant (IGC) (\$14,165)	2023
Project Preparation Grant (IGC)	2022
Pilot Grant (w. Y. Sun) (WEISS Fund) (\$8,720)	2021
Proposal Development Grant (w. Y. Sun) (KCAI JPAL) (\$41,696)	2021

Professional Activities

Seminars & Confs	2025-2026: <i>NBER SI (Development), EEA, Uganda IX's Economic Growth Forum, LSE Environmental Week, Yale University, Haas (UC Berkeley), STEG, Urban Mobility and Climate Change Conference (Harvard), Makerere University, Urbanization and Development Conference (WB), UEA (European Meeting, Planned)</i> 2024-2025: <i>TSE, University of Geneva, Bocconi University, NUS, USC, Santa Clara University, Goldman Policy (UC Berkeley), Columbia University, Northwestern University GPRL Rookiefest, BREAD, WB Infra4Dev</i> 2023-2024: <i>IGC Uganda Climate Change Workshop, JHU Cities and Development Workshop</i> 2022-2023: <i>LSE Environmental Week, WB-IGC 7th Urbanization & Poverty Res. Research Conference</i> 2021-2022: <i>NBER Summer Institute (Urban), North American Meeting of the Urban Economic Association, NEUDC, STEG Annual Conference</i> 2020-2021: <i>PacDev, European Meeting of the Urban Economic Association</i>
Refereeing Activity	<i>Journal of Environmental Economics and Management, JAERE, Journal of Transport Economics & Policy, Journal of Development Economics</i>
Other	Co-Founder and Organizer of Energy and Env. Econ. Student Sem., University of Chicago

Teaching Experience

Makerere University

Development and Environmental Economics (graduate)

Winter 2026

University of Chicago

Elements of Econ. Analysis I (undergraduate)

Fall 2023

Math Camp (graduate)

Fall 2023

App. Microeconomics in Econ. History (graduate)

Winter 2023

Environmental Economics II (graduate)

Winter 2022

El. of Econ Analysis I Honors (undergraduate)

Fall 2021

Other Writing

Urbanisation, transport and the environment: Some considerations for a more productive Kampala (with Juliana Oliveira-Cunha), *IGC Policy Brief UGA-24185*

Additional Information

Citizenship

France

Programming Skills

Julia, R, Stata, Python

Languages

French (Native), English (Fluent), Spanish (Intermediate)